young and first-time voters behind the TVK. Reports during the campaign had flagged the unusually high mobilisation among Gen Z voters, many of whom reportedly felt that the traditional Dravidian parties were 'politically exhausted'.

Several observers also noted how Vijay's political communication differed sharply from conventional poll campaigns. Instead of relying primarily on large cadre networks and traditional media outreach, the TVK appeared to have built a floating, renegade campaign around digital mobilisation, fan club conversion and extraordinary social media visibility. "The party had no structure to speak of at the ground level," says Mudhalvan, a political observer who worked on the ground in Tindivanam, near Chennai. "But obviously, the social media outreach was huge."

The Beginnings

For over three decades now, Vijay has occupied a singular space in Tamil public life: first as a filmstar dismissed as ordinary, then as one of Indian cinema's most bankable actors, and now possibly as the next chief minister of Tamil Nadu. Joseph Vijay Chandrasekhar entered cinema with both privilege and pressure. The son of filmmaker S.A. Chandrasekhar and playback singer Shoba Chandrasekhar, he faced accusations of nepotism long before it became a popular slur in Chennai's film industry. Mocked for his appearance, dialogue delivery and lack of screen presence, they said he did not have the qualities needed to become a star. That perception changed slowly. Mid-1990s romantic dramas such as *Poove Unakkaga*, *Love Today* and *Kadhalukku Mariyadhai* helped his cause, and soon Vijay had an image distinct from the hyper-masculine heroes of the time. The transformation to major star status began in the early 2000s as Tamil cinema shifted towards larger-than-life heroes, 'punch' dialogues and fan-driven spectacle. Films such as *Thirumalai*, *Ghilli*, *Thirupaachi*, *Pokkiri* and *Sivakasi* repositioned

Instead of the cadre network and traditional media outreach, the TVK had a campaign architecture rooted in digital mobilisation, fan club conversion and huge social media visibility

From Reel to Real Life Hero

Vijay's onscreen persona was cast in the mould actors-turned-politicians of yore had set in Tamil Nadu—as champion of the oppressed

By Lalitha Suhasini

An autorickshaw driver, a footballer, a cop, an army man, a lawyer, a teacher, a doctor and eventually, a chief minister—for over a decade now, Vijay's films have strategically constructed cinematic narratives that have functioned as political rehearsal. In the 2017 Tamil film *Mersal*, in which he essayed a triple role, one of his characters had him delivering a line that is in IMDB's list of Vijay's most iconic dialogues. "It takes a lifetime to create a leader. We get only one leader for a generation. A leader isn't merely a word. It stands for the trust of an entire generation," says the village wrestler, who takes on the moniker given to Vijay by the people—'Thalapathy' or 'General'.



Tamil Nadu has had a long history of political culture being intertwined with cinema. Tamil superstar M.G. Ramachandran (MGR), who was cast out of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) in 1972, went on to form the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK). He swept the polls in 1977, became chief minister and ruled Tamil Nadu for a decade. His roles, like that of a doctor who fights for the rights of rebel slaves in *Ayirathil Oruvan* (1965), elevated his profile as a champion of